

Excluding the Bounded Negative Part

Lean-checked rigidity for Erdős Problem #243

WILL COOK*

July 2026; revised September 2026

ABSTRACT

Let $a_1 < a_2 < \dots$ be positive integers with $a_{n+1}/a_n^2 \rightarrow 1$ and rational reciprocal sum, and put $P_n = \prod_{j < n} a_j$. We prove that

$$\limsup_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{P_n}{a_n} \left(\frac{a_n^2}{a_{n+1}} - 1 \right) < +\infty$$

forces $a_{n+1} = a_n^2 - a_n + 1$ eventually. In the integral tail state, bounded negative error caps upward increments, while normalised vanishing forces a nonterminal numerator to infinity. Stabilising the common divisor then supplies a Chinese remainder block that those increments cannot cross. An LCM formulation gives a weighted record criterion and the corresponding LCM-prefactor consequence. The required bound or record budget remains unproved for the unrestricted problem.

1 Introduction

For $a_n > 1$, the recurrence $a_{n+1} = a_n^2 - a_n + 1$ is singled out by the telescope

$$\frac{1}{a_n - 1} = \frac{1}{a_n} + \frac{1}{a_{n+1} - 1}.$$

Thus a Sylvester tail has the exact value $1/(a_n - 1)$ beginning at index n . The question is whether rationality and the asymptotic relation $a_{n+1} \sim a_n^2$ force that exact recurrence. The following result isolates a sufficient one-sided bound on the departure from it.

Corollary 1.1 (original-coordinate bounded defect). *Let $a_1 < a_2 < \dots$ be positive integers, $a_{n+1}/a_n^2 \rightarrow 1$, and $\sum_{n \geq 1} 1/a_n \in \mathbb{Q}$. Put $P_n = \prod_{j < n} a_j$. If*

$$\limsup_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{P_n}{a_n} \left(\frac{a_n^2}{a_{n+1}} - 1 \right) < +\infty,$$

then $a_{n+1} = a_n^2 - a_n + 1$ for all sufficiently large n .

**Authorship and AI use.* Will Cook built and directed the research infrastructure and reviewed the claims when he could. AI agents did most of the research and drafting. Cook did not independently verify every claim.

Corollary 1.1 is an ordinary transfer of the integer-state theorem below, proved in Section 4. The analytic transfer is separate from the linked Lean theorem. The separate public Lean release [wcook04/plectis-erdos-lean](https://github.com/wcook04/plectis-erdos-lean) at commit 52f29ad1 states Corollary 1.1 itself, with the defect bounded above from some index onward, as `original_coordinate_bounded_defect` in `PalomarCorpus/E243/Challenge.lean` and proves it. That repository's Linux replay of Palomar's Comparator stage accepted the entry with the Lean kernel and with NanoDa ([run 34782407633](https://github.com/leanprover-community/nano-da)).

The obstruction. Clear the rational reciprocal tail as C_n/D_n ; these are the denominator-cleared tail variables of Koizumi's pseudo-greedy formulation [9, Corollary 3, p. 9; Lemma 4, pp. 11–12]. On a Sylvester tail, $D_n = (a_n - 1)C_n$; the integer error $E_n = D_n - (a_n - 1)C_n$ measures the failure of this identity. Its update $C_{n+1} = C_n - E_n$ turns a bound on negative error into a bound on upward increments. Small increments alone are insufficient. The arithmetic input is that, after the common divisor stabilises, every old multiplier must remain coprime to every later reduced numerator. The Chinese remainder theorem then produces a block of forbidden heights that no permitted jump can cross. A numerator tending to infinity would have to cross it. Section 6 adapts this crossing argument when only jumps setting new records are charged.

Write $\text{ctr}(a, D, C) = D - (a - 1)C$. The following integer-state theorem implies Corollary 1.1; the ordinary tail transfer is proved in Section 4. Its centring hypothesis is redundant under normalised vanishing and is retained to match the source statement.

Theorem 1.2 (bounded negative part). *Let $a, C, D : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$ and $E : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$ satisfy*

1. $a_n > 1$ and $C_n > 0$ for every n ;
2. the exact dynamics $C_{n+1} + D_n = a_n C_n$ and $D_{n+1} = a_n D_n$;
3. $E_n = \text{ctr}(a_n, D_n, C_n)$ for every n ;
4. eventual strict centring: $|E_n| < C_n$ for all large n ;
5. eventually bounded negative part: $-B \leq E_n$ for all large n , for some B ;
6. normalised vanishing: for every K there is an N with $K|E_n| < C_n$ for all $n \geq N$.

Then $E_n = 0$ for all sufficiently large n : this is the *eventual bounded-negative rigidity*.

The Lean proof shifts the orbit past the centring and lower-bound thresholds and applies the *bounded-negative-part rigidity*, with centring and bound at every index.

Problem 1.3 (Erdős #243). Let $1 \leq a_1 < a_2 < \dots$ be a sequence of integers with

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{a_n}{a_{n-1}^2} = 1 \quad \text{and} \quad \sum \frac{1}{a_n} \in \mathbb{Q}.$$

Then $a_n = a_{n-1}^2 - a_{n-1} + 1$ for all sufficiently large n .

The question is recorded by Erdős and Graham [5] and by Erdős [6, p. 105], and Bloom's catalogue lists it as Problem #243 [10].

The additional hypothesis in Theorem 1.2 is the lower bound on E_n . The growth and rationality assumptions already supply the other state hypotheses after a finite shift.

The nonnegative-error case, Badea's criterion [3, Corollary 2.2, p. 316] in Koizumi's coordinates, is integer descent [9, Proposition 1(2), p. 14]; the theorem allows arbitrary sign changes with bounded negative depth. The published product-weighted criterion, stated as Koizumi's Corollary 4(1), assumes a nonpositive upper limit [9, pp. 14–15], and Corollary 1.1 allows any finite upper limit. Bado's preprint, posted in September 2026, assumes two-sided bounded errors [7, Theorem 5.1, p. 4]; Theorem 1.2 needs only an eventual lower bound.

2 Proof of bounded-negative rigidity

The arithmetic ingredients are proved immediately afterwards. Normalised vanishing and integrality give $C_n \rightarrow \infty$ on a nonzero tail, while the lower error bound gives $C_{n+1} \leq C_n + B$.

Proof of Theorem 1.2. Suppose not. We first remove every late zero: by Theorem 3.2 and its contrapositive form, E is nowhere zero beyond the centring threshold. Two cases remain. If E is negative cofinally, then (5) bounds those magnitudes, so Proposition 3.7 makes the tail gcd stabilise and the orbit may be taken reduced past that point. Hypothesis (5) with Proposition 3.1 gives $C_{n+1} \leq C_n + B$, a bounded rise; hypothesis (6) with E nowhere zero gives $C_n \rightarrow \infty$. A reduced exact tail with a divergent numerator and bounded rise is excluded by Theorem 3.5. It remains to treat the case that E is eventually positive, and there the descent of Theorem 3.2 applies and forces E to vanish, contradicting nowhere-vanishing. $\square$

Corollary 2.1. *Under Theorem 1.2, the multipliers satisfy $a_{n+1} = a_n^2 - a_n + 1$ eventually.*

Proof. Apply the two-zero implication in Corollary 3.3 below. $\square$

3 The arithmetic ingredients

3.1 Error, absorption and descent

The identities below are algebraic consequences of Koizumi's state recurrence [9, Lemmas 2–4, pp. 10–12]. In his coordinates the absorption of Theorem 3.2 is his Lemma 3 [9, p. 10], and the nonnegative-error descent is his Proposition 1(2) [9, p. 14], which he attributes to Badea [3, Corollary 2.2, p. 316]. The conventions here are those of the formalisation.

Write $\Delta_n = a_{n+1} - (a_n^2 - a_n + 1)$.

Proposition 3.1 (error identities). *For an exact integer state,*

$$C_{n+1} = C_n - E_n, \quad \Delta_n C_{n+1} = a_n^2 E_n - E_{n+1}.$$

Proof. Substitute $E_n = D_n - (a_n - 1)C_n$ and use $D_{n+1} = a_n D_n$, $C_{n+1} = a_n C_n - D_n$. $\square$

Both identities are the [update law](#) and the [defect identity](#).

Theorem 3.2 (absorption and descent). *For a positive exact state with strict centring, $E_n = 0$ implies $E_{n+1} = 0$. For any positive integer state with $C_{n+1} = C_n - E_n$, eventual nonnegativity of E_n implies its eventual vanishing.*

Proof. When $E_n = 0$, the second identity makes E_{n+1} a multiple of C_{n+1} ; strict centring forces that multiple to be zero. In the second assertion, C_n is eventually a nonincreasing sequence of positive integers, so it stabilises. $\square$

Both assertions are [absorption of a vanishing centred state](#) and [stabilisation of the non-negative error](#).

Corollary 3.3 (two zero errors). *If $E_n = E_{n+1} = 0$ and $C_{n+1} \neq 0$, then $a_{n+1} = a_n^2 - a_n + 1$. Thus eventual zero error in a positive exact state implies the eventual Sylvester recurrence.*

Proof. The second error identity has nonzero factor C_{n+1} . $\square$

The local and eventual forms are the [local rigidity step](#) and the [eventual Sylvester recurrence](#).

Absorption holds after any eventual centring threshold. On a nonterminal tail it removes all subsequent zeros. Then $|E_n| \geq 1$, so normalised vanishing gives $C_n \rightarrow \infty$.

3.2 The first-crossing obstruction

Lemma 3.4 (consecutive multiples). *For pairwise coprime integers $m_0, \dots, m_{B-1} \geq 2$ and every lower bound, there is a larger t such that $m_i \mid t + i$ for each $i < B$.*

Proof. Solve $t \equiv -i \pmod{m_i}$ by the Chinese remainder theorem, then add multiples of $\prod_i m_i$. $\square$

Lemma 3.4 matches each modulus m_i to its own multiple $t + i$ inside a window of B consecutive integers. The same forbidden block and first-crossing contradiction, under a two-sided bound on the error, appear in the proof of Bado's Theorem 5.1 [7, pp. 4–5]. The lemma here isolates bounded upward movement, and the gcd stabilisation below makes it applicable with only a lower bound on the error.

Theorem 3.5 (bounded-rise obstruction). *Let $u_n \in \mathbb{N}$ tend to infinity with $u_{n+1} \leq u_n + B$, for a fixed integer $B > 0$. There is no infinite pairwise coprime family $m_i \geq 2$ with $\gcd(m_i, u_t) = 1$ whenever $i < t$.*

Proof. Choose $m_0, \dots, m_{B-1}$ and use Lemma 3.4 to find $t > \max(u_0, \dots, u_B)$ with $m_i \mid t + i$. Since $u_n \rightarrow \infty$, there is a first $n > B$ with $u_n \geq t$. Minimality and the rise bound give

$$t \leq u_n \leq u_{n-1} + B < t + B.$$

Hence $u_n = t + i$ for some $0 \leq i < B < n$, so $m_i \mid u_n$. This contradicts $\gcd(m_i, u_n) = 1$. The argument uses first crossing, not monotonicity: the numerator may fall before it reaches the block. $\square$

3.3 Reduction and stabilisation

A reduced exact tail has positive u_n , integer $v_n \geq 0$, $\gcd(u_n, v_n) = 1$, and

$$u_{n+1} = a_n u_n - v_n, \quad v_{n+1} = a_n v_n.$$

Proposition 3.6 (persistent coprimality). *In a reduced exact tail, $\gcd(a_n, v_n) = 1$. Distinct multipliers are pairwise coprime, and every earlier multiplier is coprime to every later numerator.*

Proof. A common prime divisor of a_n, v_n would divide both u_{n+1} and v_{n+1} . Also, $a_i \mid v_t$ for $i < t$, so reducedness gives $\gcd(a_i, u_t) = 1$, and $\gcd(a_t, v_t) = 1$ gives $\gcd(a_i, a_t) = 1$. $\square$

All three conclusions are the [step coprimality](#), the [pairwise coprimality](#), and the [whole-modulus avoidance](#).

Proposition 3.7 (gcd stabilisation). *For a positive exact state, if negative errors have bounded magnitudes along a cofinal set of indices, then $G_n = \gcd(C_n, D_n)$ eventually stabilises. Division by its stable value gives a reduced exact tail.*

Proof. Both updates preserve common divisors, so $G_n \mid G_{n+1}$. Moreover $G_n \mid E_n$, hence $G_n \leq -E_n$ at a negative index. The positive divisibility chain is bounded along a cofinal set and therefore bounded everywhere; it eventually stabilises. Division by the stable value preserves both exact updates and leaves the states coprime. $\square$

The stable gcd is [gcd stabilisation](#).

In the main proof, division by the stable gcd preserves divergence and a bounded upward increment. Theorem 3.5 therefore applies to the reduced numerator: this is the [eventual reduced exclusion](#). With normalised vanishing the same obstruction is the [exclusion from normalised vanishing](#). Sparse changes of the gcd without eventual stabilisation are a different statement; the supporting record retains that distinction and its finite-block consequences.

4 Transfer to a reciprocal series

The variables below are Koizumi's denominator-cleared rational tail [9, Lemma 4, pp. 11–12], with the indexing and the common clearing factor used here. Let $x_n = \sum_{k \geq n} 1/a_k$, suppose $x_1 = p/q$ with $q > 0$, and put

$$P_n = \prod_{j < n} a_j, \quad D_n = qP_n, \quad C_n = D_n x_n.$$

Each C_n is a positive integer, since D_n clears the rational sum and every term of the preceding finite prefix. The tail relation $x_n = 1/a_n + x_{n+1}$ gives the exact state updates.

Quadratic growth gives $a_n \geq \exp(c2^n)$ eventually for some $c > 0$ and

$$x_n = \frac{1}{a_n} + \frac{1}{a_{n+1}} + O(a_{n+1}^{-2}).$$

Consequently

$$\frac{C_{n+1}}{C_n} = \frac{a_n x_{n+1}}{x_n} = \frac{a_n^2}{a_{n+1}} + O(1/a_n) \rightarrow 1, \quad \frac{E_n}{C_n} \rightarrow 0.$$

Thus strict centring also holds eventually. These are the ordinary canonical-tail implications of Koizumi's work. After a finite shift the sequence is the pseudo-greedy expansion of its own tail sum, with gap sequence tending to zero [9, Corollary 3, p. 9]. On that tail the integers c_n, d_n and e_n of his Lemma 4 [9, pp. 11–12] are C_n, D_n and E_n up to one common positive factor, and his range $-c_n/2 \leq e_n < c_n/2$ gives $|E_n| < C_n$.

Proof of Corollary 1.1. Put $\gamma_n = a_n^2/a_{n+1} - 1$. Since

$$\frac{P_{n+1}/a_{n+1}}{P_n/a_n} = 1 + \gamma_n \rightarrow 1, \quad P_n/a_n = \exp(o(n)),$$

the two-term estimate gives

$$\begin{aligned} E_n &= \frac{qP_n}{a_n} - \frac{qP_n(a_n - 1)}{a_{n+1}} + O\left(\frac{qP_n a_n}{a_{n+1}^2}\right), \\ q\frac{P_n}{a_n}\gamma_n &= \frac{qP_n a_n}{a_{n+1}} - \frac{qP_n}{a_n}. \end{aligned}$$

Adding cancels the two terms of size qP_n/a_n and leaves

$$E_n + q\frac{P_n}{a_n}\gamma_n = \frac{qP_n}{a_{n+1}} + O\left(\frac{qP_n a_n}{a_{n+1}^2}\right) = o(1). \quad (1)$$

Indeed, quadratic growth makes the two terms on the right respectively $\exp(o(n))/a_n$ and $\exp(o(n))/a_n^2$, up to bounded factors. The assumed upper bound therefore gives an eventual lower bound on the integer E_n . After deleting a finite prefix, all hypotheses of Theorem 1.2 hold. Apply Corollary 2.1. $\square$

Identity (1) is the product-weighted comparison used in Koizumi's proof of his Corollary 4(1) [9, (11)–(12), p. 15], written in the canonical variables.

The same calculation is valid with qP_n replaced by any positive clearance $H_n \leq qP_n$: if $W_n = H_n x_n$ and $Z_n = H_n - (a_n - 1)W_n$, then

$$Z_n + \frac{H_n}{a_n}\gamma_n = o(1). \quad (2)$$

This will supply the LCM-prefactor consequence below.

5 A scalar finite-mass criterion

Theorem 5.1 (finite negative relative mass). *Let C_n be positive integers and E_n integers satisfying $C_{n+1} = C_n - E_n$. If*

$$\sum_n \frac{(-E_n)_+}{C_n} < \infty,$$

then $E_n = 0$ eventually. No denominator dynamics or normalised vanishing is required.

Proof. Set $\delta_n = (-E_n)_+ / C_n$. Then

$$C_N \leq C_0 \prod_{n < N} (1 + \delta_n) \leq C_0 \exp\left(\sum_n \delta_n\right).$$

Choose an integer upper bound K for C_n . Each strict rise contributes at least $1/K$ to $\sum \delta_n$, so there are only finitely many rises. The remaining positive integer sequence is nonincreasing and stabilises. $\square$

The product argument is the [summable relative growth](#); its specialisation to negative mass is the [vanishing from finite negative mass](#), and the statement giving the recurrence directly is the [Sylvester recurrence from summable negative mass](#). The elementary growth comparison is [tail growth](#).

On an exact reciprocal-tail orbit the conclusion gives the Sylvester recurrence. For the gap sequence of the pseudo-greedy expansion, the same criterion, with the same product bound and integer descent, appears in the Erdős Problem a Day working report on Problem #243, dated 12 August 2026 [8, “A global termination criterion”]; the statement above is for any positive integer sequence with $C_{n+1} = C_n - E_n$. The scalar criterion and bounded negative error are distinct quantities to estimate; on the common exact-orbit class with normalised vanishing they are each equivalent to the same endpoint.

6 Weighted first crossings of LCM records

Only steps setting an LCM numerator record need contribute. The first-crossing argument permits subtraction of a fixed baseline and any decreasing weight with divergent integral. The theorem in this section has an ordinary proof. The LCM coordinates below also appear in Bado’s preprint of September 2026: with his denominator parameter equal to q , his M_{n-1} , Δ_{n-1} , K_{n-1} , u_n and g_n are the L_n , M_n , U_n , V_n and ρ_n defined here, and his (19) is the update $\rho_n U_{n+1} = U_n - V_n$ [7, Prop. 7.1 and (16)–(20), pp. 6–7]; the contraction at a reuse step is his (34) [7, p. 9].

Set

$$L_n = \text{lcm}(q, a_1, \dots, a_{n-1}), \quad M_n = D_n / L_n, \quad U_n = C_n / M_n, \quad V_n = E_n / M_n.$$

The rational tail has denominator dividing L_n , so U_n and V_n are integers. With $\rho_n = \text{gcd}(L_n, a_n)$, the exact updates are

$$M_{n+1} = M_n \rho_n, \quad \rho_n U_{n+1} = U_n - V_n, \quad V_n = L_n - (a_n - 1)U_n.$$

Write $R_n = \max_{j \leq n} U_j$ and $\mathcal{R} = \{n : U_{n+1} > R_n\}$. Strict centring already gives $U_{n+1} < U_n$ when $\rho_n \geq 2$, so every sufficiently late strict rise has $\rho_n = 1$. The stronger eventual bound $-U_n \leq 2V_n$, supplied by $V_n / U_n = E_n / C_n \rightarrow 0$, gives the quantitative estimate $U_{n+1} \leq 3U_n / 4$ when $\rho_n \geq 2$. Its actual jump is therefore $d_n = U_{n+1} - U_n = -V_n$.

Theorem 6.1 (weighted record excess). *Assume the growth and rationality hypotheses of Problem 1.3. Let $f : [1, \infty) \rightarrow [0, \infty)$ be finite and nonincreasing, with $\int_1^\infty f(t) dt = \infty$. Then the sequence is eventually Sylvester if and only if, for some integer $B \geq 0$,*

$$\sum_{n \in \mathcal{R}} (-V_n - B)_+ f(U_n) < \infty.$$

Proof. Suppose the sequence is not eventually Sylvester. Absorption and integrality give $1/U_n \leq |V_n|/U_n = |E_n|/C_n \rightarrow 0$, so there are infinitely many record steps. Every sufficiently late record is fresh. Their digits are pairwise coprime: an earlier digit divides the later L_n , while the digit at a fresh record is coprime to L_n . For any fixed $B \geq 1$, choose B such digits $m_0, \dots, m_{B-1} > B$ and take T after their indices.

Put $P = \prod_i m_i$ and choose x by the Chinese remainder theorem with $m_i \mid x + i$. Consider all translates $\tau = x + B + kP > R_T, k \in \mathbb{Z}$; the first is at most $R_T + P$. A first crossing $U_n \leq R_n < \tau \leq U_n + d_n$ is a record step. If $d_n \leq B$, then $U_n \in [\tau - B, \tau)$, so some m_i divides U_n . It also divides L_n , hence divides $d_n = (a_n - 1)U_n - L_n$, contradicting $0 < d_n \leq B < m_i$.

If the step first crosses $h \geq 1$ such heights, their spacing gives $(h - 1)P < d_n$. With $r = d_n - B \geq 1$ and $P \geq B + 1$, we have $d_n = B + r \leq Pr$, whence $h \leq r$. Monotonicity of f now gives

$$\sum_{\substack{\tau \text{ first crossed} \\ \text{at step } n}} f(\tau) \leq (d_n - B)f(U_n).$$

Each height above R_T has one first crossing. Summing, and comparing each interval of length P with its left endpoint, yields the finite bound

$$\sum_{\substack{T \leq n < N \\ n \in \mathcal{R}}} (-V_n - B)_+ f(U_n) \geq \frac{1}{P} \int_{R_T+P}^{R_N} f(t) dt. \quad (3)$$

Since $R_n \rightarrow \infty$, the right side diverges for every $B \geq 1$; $B = 0$ follows by domination. Conversely a Sylvester tail telescopes to $x_n = 1/(a_n - 1)$, so $V_n = 0$ eventually. $\square$

For example, $f(t) = 1/[t \log(et)]$ gives the sufficient condition

$$\sum_{n \in \mathcal{R}} \frac{(-V_n - B)_+}{U_n \log(eU_n)} < \infty.$$

Its finite lower bound in (3) is $P^{-1} \log(\log(eR_N)/\log(e(R_T + P)))$. Further fixed iterated logarithmic factors are allowed whenever the integral still diverges. These are specialisations of one crossing theorem.

The criterion also has an exact expression in the original growth defect. Put $\gamma_n = a_n^2/a_{n+1} - 1$ and $\theta_n = E_n/C_n$. The defect identity gives

$$\gamma_n + \theta_n = \frac{(1 - \theta_n)(a_n - 1 + \theta_{n+1})}{a_{n+1}}, \quad 0 < \gamma_n + \theta_n < 3/a_n$$

eventually. Thus the two nonnegative summands $U_n f(U_n)(\gamma_n - B/U_n)_+$ and $(-V_n - B)_+ f(U_n)$ differ by at most $3U_n f(U_n)/a_n$. This is summable because $U_n \leq C_n = \exp(o(n))$, $f(U_n) \leq f(1)$, and $a_n \geq \exp(c2^n)$ eventually for some $c > 0$. Consequently Theorem 6.1 is equivalent to finiteness of

$$\sum_{n \in \mathcal{R}} U_n f(U_n) \left(\frac{a_n^2}{a_{n+1}} - 1 - \frac{B}{U_n} \right)_+ \quad (4)$$

for some B . The original hypotheses do not currently supply this finiteness. In particular, termwise convergence to zero is insufficient. Also, d_n is the actual jump, including any recovery from a drawdown; it must not be replaced by $R_{n+1} - R_n$ in the crossing proof.

Corollary 6.2 (LCM-weighted bounded defect). *Assume the hypotheses of Problem 1.3. Write $A_n = \text{lcm}(a_1, \dots, a_{n-1})$ with $A_1 = 1$ and*

$$Z_n = \frac{A_n}{a_n} \left(\frac{a_n^2}{a_{n+1}} - 1 \right).$$

If $\limsup Z_n < \infty$, then the sequence is eventually Sylvester.

Proof. Put $t_n = L_n/A_n = q/\gcd(q, A_n)$, so $1 \leq t_n \leq q$. Equation (2), with $H_n = L_n$, gives $V_n + t_n Z_n = o(1)$. A finite upper bound on Z_n therefore bounds the negative part of V_n . The record series vanishes after a finite prefix for a sufficiently large baseline, so Theorem 6.1 applies. $\square$

Erdős and Straus assume a nonpositive upper limit in the corresponding next-index LCM expression [1, Theorem 3, p. 132], and Tijdeman and Yuan give a criterion of the same kind for positive numerators [4]. Here any finite upper bound suffices under the quadratic-limit assumption. Since $A_n \mid P_n$, this also implies Corollary 1.1: multiplication by a factor in $(0, 1]$ preserves an upper bound, including at negative values.

Lean checks Corollary 6.2 as the [original-coordinate LCM bounded defect](#). That declaration takes the rational reciprocal sum and the quadratic growth limit as hypotheses, with the finite upper limsup recorded as an eventual upper bound on Z_n ; it assumes no divisibility of the denominator by the prefix LCM.

Duverney proved a conditional signed form of the problem itself: for signs $\epsilon_n \in \{-1, 1\}$, if $\sum_{n \geq 0} (a_{n+1}/a_n^2 - 1)$ converges, then the reciprocal sum with numerators ϵ_n is rational if and only if

$$a_{n+1} = a_n^2 - (\epsilon_{n+1}/\epsilon_n)a_n + \epsilon_{n+2}/\epsilon_{n+1}$$

for all large n [2, Corollary 3.2, p. 287]. Absolute convergence is a stronger sufficient specialisation, not the hypothesis printed in that corollary. The all-positive specialisation is the form relevant here.

The divisor constraint also survives integral numerator coefficients: $d = (a_n - 1)U_n - b_n L_n$ is divisible by every divisor of both U_n, L_n . An ordinary coefficient-uniform variant gives bounded LCM height from a bounded negative part; normalised vanishing is used afterwards for stationarity. For positive numerator coefficients the classical comparators are Badea's Corollary 2.2 [3, p. 316] and the criterion of Tijdeman and Yuan [4]. Its proof and exact bounded-height counterexamples are in the [coefficient proof supplement](#).

7 Further consequences

Theorem 7.1 (cubic-rate irrationality). *A strictly increasing sequence of positive integers with*

$$a_n^2/a_{n+1} = 1 + \frac{3}{n} + o(n^{-3})$$

has irrational reciprocal sum.

Proof by the polynomial exclusion. Under rationality, the canonical estimate gives $C_{n+1}/C_n = 1 + 3/n + o(n^{-3})$. Integer finite differences force $C_n = An(n+1)(n+2) + B$ eventually. The fixed-cubic exclusion rules this out. The complete ordinary polynomial and number-field argument is retained in [the proof supplement, Section 8](#); finite congruence checks alone are insufficient for that implication. $\square$

The same finite-difference extraction excludes every nonintegral $\lambda > 1$ under the rate $a_n^2/a_{n+1} = 1 + \lambda/n + o(n^{-\lambda})$: eventual polynomial growth would force its degree to equal λ . These rates fall outside $1 + o(1/n)$, the rate at which Koizumi notes that the Erdős–Straus criterion settles the problem [9, Remark 3, p. 16], and they make Duverney’s signed series $\sum_n (a_{n+1}/a_n^2 - 1)$ diverge.

For $x_1 = p/q$ the integer C_n of Section 4 is q times the linear form $P_n x_1 - P_n \sum_{k < n} 1/a_k$, whose coefficients are integers. Approximation criteria for irrationality use nonzero forms of this kind that tend to zero. At the cubic rate these forms grow: since $a_n x_n \rightarrow 1$, the identity $(P_{n+1}/a_{n+1})/(P_n/a_n) = 1 + \gamma_n$ of Section 4 makes $C_n/q = P_n x_n$ a positive multiple of $n(n+1)(n+2)$ up to a factor tending to one. The proof of Theorem 7.1 uses the rate at precision $o(n^{-3})$: for a rational sum it forces the exact profile $C_n = An(n+1)(n+2) + B$, which is then excluded.

There is also an admitted quantitative extension. Under the hypotheses of Theorem 1.2 other than (5), put $LL(x) = \log_2 \log_2 \max(4, x)$. Each fixed $\delta \in (0, 1)$ gives

$$(-E_n)_+ \leq (1 - \delta) LL(C_n) \text{ eventually} \implies E_n = 0 \text{ eventually.}$$

The LCM version needs the corresponding bound only at late record steps. The proofs use a CRT block in $[P, 2P)$ and the canonical multiplier scale; they are retained in [the slow-negative proof](#) and [the record-only extension](#). These are ordinary results with stated rate hypotheses; neither establishes the general record budget.

8 The remaining arithmetic estimate

Proposition 8.1 (necessary profile). *The canonical state of a counterexample has $E_n \neq 0$ eventually, $|E_n|/C_n \rightarrow 0$, unbounded negative magnitudes along negative indices, and*

$$\sum_n \frac{(-E_n)_+}{C_n} = \infty.$$

Proof. Absorption excludes late zeros, descent excludes an eventually nonnegative error, and Theorems 1.2 and 5.1 exclude the two finiteness conditions. $\square$

Problem 8.2 (global overlap-height growth). For every nonterminal canonical orbit satisfying Problem 1.3, must

$$\limsup_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{\log M_n}{n} > 0?$$

Equivalently, must there be a $K \geq 1$ for which

$$2^n \leq M_n^K$$

at infinitely many indices?

The canonical necessary profile is ordinary in this note, and Lean checks it as [the canonical frontier profile](#), from the rational reciprocal sum and the quadratic growth limit.

For $B \geq 0$ put

$$F_B(X) = \sum_{\substack{n \in \mathcal{R} \\ U_n \leq X}} (-V_n - B)_+.$$

The remaining equivalent estimate is

$$\exists B \in \mathbb{N} : \quad \liminf_{X \rightarrow \infty} \frac{F_B(X)}{X} = 0. \quad (5)$$

On a nonterminal orbit first crossings instead give $F_B(X) \geq X/P_B - O_B(1)$, with an orbit-dependent CRT modulus P_B . The missing step is to derive (5) from the canonical dynamics. Its equivalence with the existence of an admissible weight is the following elementary lemma, applied to the record charges $u_j = U_n$ and $w_j = (-V_n - B)_+$ over $n \in \mathcal{R}$ at a fixed B .

Lemma 8.3 (weights and linear density). *Let u_j be positive integers, let $w_j \geq 0$, and put $F(X) = \sum_{u_j \leq X} w_j$. Then $\liminf_{X \rightarrow \infty} F(X)/X = 0$ if and only if there is a finite nonincreasing $f : [1, \infty) \rightarrow [0, \infty)$ with $\int_1^\infty f(t) dt = \infty$ and $\sum_j w_j f(u_j) < \infty$.*

Proof. Suppose the lower limit vanishes. Since F is constant on each $[m, m+1)$, there are integers $X_1 < X_2 < \dots$ with $X_k \geq 2^k$ and $F(X_k) \leq 2^{-k} X_k$. Put $f = \sum_{k \geq 1} X_k^{-1} \mathbf{1}_{[1, X_k]}$, which is nonincreasing and bounded by $\sum_k 2^{-k}$. Then $\int_1^\infty f = \sum_k (1 - 1/X_k) = \infty$, while interchanging the nonnegative sums gives $\sum_j w_j f(u_j) = \sum_k F(X_k)/X_k \leq 1$.

Conversely, let f be such a weight and suppose $F(m) \geq cm$ for some $c > 0$ and all integers $m \geq M$. A nonincreasing nonnegative function with divergent integral is positive everywhere, so $F(X) \leq f(X)^{-1} \sum_j w_j f(u_j)$ is finite. Partial summation gives, for $N > M$,

$$\sum_{u_j \leq N} w_j f(u_j) = F(N)f(N) + \sum_{m=1}^{N-1} F(m)(f(m) - f(m+1)) \geq c(Mf(M) + \sum_{m=M+1}^N f(m)),$$

every term being nonnegative. The right side diverges as $N \rightarrow \infty$, because $\sum_{m \geq 1} f(m) \geq \int_1^\infty f(t) dt = \infty$. $\square$

The lemma converts the weighted criterion into the displayed density condition; suppling (5) for a canonical orbit remains open.

The obstruction is the exact unit-numerator feedback at the record sources. The scalar sequence $C_n = n^2 + 1$, $E_n = -(2n + 1)$ has normalised vanishing, subexponential height and finite square mass, but is not an exact reciprocal-tail orbit: its numerator word $0, 0, 2 \pmod{5}$ violates the persistent-zero transport of the exact equations. Likewise, small rises and avoidance of an arbitrary sparse coprime family do not control the canonical timing and size of the available divisors. The supporting record keeps those falsifying examples with the exact hypotheses each preserves.

Formal scope and supporting record. The bounded-negative state theorem is checked in Lean 4 against Mathlib at the stated source checkpoint: [eventual bounded-negative rigidity](#). Lean also checks the endpoint that carries that theorem to the original denominators, as [the bounded-negative-part recurrence theorem](#), and the canonical analytic transfer of Corollary 6.2, as [the original-coordinate LCM bounded defect](#). The global weighted, polynomial and slow-negative arguments are ordinary proofs; the scalar finite-mass proof is printed in full above. The auxiliary source guide, the [eventual constant exclusion](#) and the [eventual periodic exclusion](#), primitive feedback, finite certificates and unsuccessful global extensions belong to the accompanying reasoning record. Their stronger global producer hypotheses remain explicit.

Declarations. The authorship and AI-use statement on the first page applies to this manuscript. Code and mathematical source are available at the repository checkpoint 99f4bf47422a. A source declaration establishes only its own statement; the ordinary transfer and the unresolved estimate above are separately identified.

A Guide to the formal sources

Each linked phrase opens its Lean declaration at the pinned source revision 99f4bf47422a. The state system, the exclusions, the barrier, and the bounded-negative-part theorem are in `ReciprocalTailRigidity.lean`; the finite-negative-mass theorem is in `SparseResetRecovery.lean`; and the repair-entropy inequalities are in `RepairEntropy.lean`. The residue reduction of Appendix B is in `FiniteHorizonResidue.lean`. Three distinctions are worth carrying into the source. The identification of any of these modules with reciprocal tails is the exposition of Section 4 and is not a checked statement. The periodic exclusion assumes the regime $e_n < a_n$. And the final Lean declaration lists strict centring and normalised vanishing as hypotheses; the former follows eventually from the latter with $K = 1$, while the formal source derives neither from the original analytic problem. The ordinary canonical-tail transfer is proved in Section 4.

B A factorial residue reduction for forced orbits

A constant-negative error $E_n = -m$ with $C_0 = c$ produces $C_n = c + nm$ and the shape equation

$$D_n + m = (a_n - 1)C_n. \quad (6)$$

In the case $m = c = 1$, where (6) reads $D_n + 1 = (a_n - 1)(n + 1)$, each multiplier is determined by its predecessor; we call such an orbit *forced*. At index n the numerator of the next multiplier is

$$\text{num}(n, a) = (n + 1)a^2 - (n + 2)a + (n + 3),$$

the [forced numerator](#), and the divisor is $n + 2$. The orbit survives a step when that division is exact, giving a survival predicate, the [survival predicate](#).

Example B.1 (the shape equation running until it fails). The forced orbit from $a = 3$ reads this way: $\text{num}(0, 3) = 6$ is divisible by 2 and gives $a_1 = 3$, while $\text{num}(1, 3) = 13$ is not divisible by 3, so the orbit stops there.

Deciding survival by iteration is expensive because the orbit grows doubly exponentially, and it is unnecessary: survival over a finite horizon depends on the initial value only through a factorial residue. Computing a pseudo-greedy orbit through residues modulo a shrinking product modulus is Koizumi’s method [9, Remark 2 and Algorithm 1, pp. 13–14]; for the forced numerator that product is a factorial.

Theorem B.2 (factorial residue reduction). *For all h and all integers $a \equiv b \pmod{(h+1)!}$, the orbit from a survives h forced updates exactly when the orbit from b does.*

Proof. Let $M(0, i) = 1$ and $M(h+1, i) = (i+2)M(h, i+1)$, an ascending factorial with $M(h, 0) = (h+1)!$. The numerator is a polynomial with integer coefficients, so congruences transfer; reducing the modulus gives divisibility by $i+2$ for one exactly when for the other, and cancelling that common factor from both values and modulus leaves the inductive hypothesis at $M(h, i+1)$. $\square$

Formalised as the [factorial residue reduction](#), over the [shrinking-modulus transport](#), the [polynomial congruence](#), and the [exact-division cancellation](#); the modulus identifications are the [ascending-factorial form](#) and the [factorial value at the initial index](#).

At $h = 1$ the modulus is $2! = 2$, and surviving one update means $2 \mid a^2 - 2a + 3$, which holds exactly for odd a : for instance $\text{num}(0, 3) = 6$ but $\text{num}(0, 4) = 11$. So one step of survival is decided by the parity of a alone, which is Theorem B.2 at its smallest nontrivial horizon.

The search this supported is superseded. Running it over initial states below 5000 produced forced prefixes of length 17 and no longer, which was evidence and not a proof; the Lean-checked [constant exclusion at every scale](#) now excludes the constant-negative case outright, for every seed and at every scale. The reduction is retained because it is exact, and because the shrinking-modulus technique transfers to any forced orbit whose step is a polynomial division.

References

- [1] P. Erdős and E. G. Straus, *On the irrationality of certain Ahmes series*, J. Indian Math. Soc. (N.S.) **27** (1964), 129–133. MR 175848.
- [2] D. Duverney, *Irrationality of fast converging series of rational numbers*, J. Math. Sci. Univ. Tokyo **8** (2001), 275–316. MR 1837165.
- [3] C. Badea, *A theorem on irrationality of infinite series and applications*, Acta Arith. **63** (1993), no. 4, 313–323, doi:10.4064/aa-63-4-313-323.
- [4] R. Tijdeman and P. Yuan, *On the rationality of Cantor and Ahmes series*, Indag. Math. (N.S.) **13** (2002), no. 3, 407–418, doi:10.1016/S0019-3577(02)80018-0.
- [5] P. Erdős and R. L. Graham, *Old and New Problems and Results in Combinatorial Number Theory*, Monogr. Enseign. Math. 28, Geneva, 1980, p. 64.

- [6] P. Erdős, *On the irrationality of certain series: problems and results*, in A. Baker (ed.), *New Advances in Transcendence Theory*, Cambridge UP, 1988, pp. 102–109, doi:[10.1017/CBO9780511897184.009](https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511897184.009).
- [7] I. O. Bado, *Prime-Support Rigidity and Primitive Pseudo-Greedy Dynamics: Partial Progress on Erdős Problem #243*, preprint posted September 2026, doi:[10.13140/RG.2.2.36612.08325](https://doi.org/10.13140/RG.2.2.36612.08325).
- [8] P. White with Claude (Anthropic), *Erdős #243: working report*, Erdős Problem a Day, page dated 12 August 2026, accessed 16 September 2026. An AI-assisted working report; it has not been refereed.
- [9] J. Koizumi, *Irrationality of the reciprocal sum of doubly exponential sequences*, *Integers* **26** (2026), Paper No. A28, 17 pp., doi:[10.5281/zenodo.18714404](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.18714404); preprint arXiv:2504.05933v1.
- [10] T. F. Bloom, *Erdős Problem #243*, erdosproblems.com/243, accessed 28 July 2026 (page displays “last edited 21 January 2026”). The record labels the problem open and cites [ErGr80, p. 64] and [Er88c, p. 105].

Companion system context. The [claim and trust boundary](#), [cold-clone route to proof authority](#), and [public contribution protocol](#) are described in sibling papers. Those descriptions do not change the mathematical status of this note.